

Publishing Guide: The Emperor Who Would Not Kneel

How to Pitch Your Manga

What You Need (You Already Have Most of This!)

What You Have:

- **Complete Arc 1:** 12 chapters (~295 pages) in professional manga script format
- **Story Bible:** Character profiles, world-building documents, premise
- **Visual Direction:** Art notes and style guide
- **Professional Format:** Right-to-left manga scripts ready for an artist

What You Still Need:

- **An Artist Partner:** Most publishers require a complete creative team (writer + artist)
- **Sequential Art Samples:** 5-20 pages of fully illustrated, inked, and lettered manga pages
- **Character Designs (Settei):** Professional character turnarounds (front, side, back views)

The Standard Pitch Packet

Publishers expect a professional package containing:

1. **Logline** (1-2 sentences)
 - Example: "A Black former conqueror dies and refuses to kneel to Heaven or Hell, forging a third path in the afterlife where choice matters more than command."
 2. **Synopsis** (1-2 pages)
 - Beginning, middle, and END (editors want to know the full arc)
 - Include your vision for multiple arcs
 3. **Character Profiles & Designs**
 - Egris, The Reaper, God, Satan, Arghun, Borchu, Suro, etc.
 - Turnaround sheets showing front, side, and back views
 - Expression sheets showing emotional range
 4. **Sequential Art**
 - **The "Name" (Storyboard):** Publishers prioritize storyboards to evaluate pacing
 - **Finished Pages:** 5-20 pages of fully illustrated, inked, toned, and lettered samples
 - Tip: Adapt scenes from Chapter 1 or 7 as your sample
 5. **Creator Bio & Comparable Titles**
 - Your background
 - "Comps" like: Chainsaw Man (refusal of divine power), Vinland Saga (philosophical action), Hell's Paradise (afterlife setting)
-

Who to Approach

Tier 1: Best Fit for Your Project (Dark Fantasy/Seinen)

Dark Horse Comics

- **Why:** Known for mature, high-concept dark fantasy (Berserk, Hellboy)
- **Accepts:** Unsolicited submissions (selective)
- **Your Advantage:** “The Emperor Who Would Not Kneel” fits their mature, philosophical action niche
- **Submission:** <https://www.darkhorse.com/>

Image Comics

- **Why:** Industry leader for creator-owned properties
- **Accepts:** Only from complete creative teams (writer + artist)
- **Your Advantage:** You retain 100% of IP rights
- **Submission:** Requires professional polish; no slush pile

Seven Seas Entertainment

- **Why:** More accessible than legacy publishers, focuses on English-speaking markets
 - **Accepts:** Original manga submissions
 - **Your Advantage:** They publish dark fantasy and seinen
-

Tier 2: Independent & OEL Publishers

Saturday AM

- **Why:** Leader in “diverse manga” (shonen/seinen), actively seeks BIPOC creators
- **Accepts:** Periodic recruitment events (“Summer of Manga”)
- **Your Advantage:** Your Black protagonist fits their diversity mission
- **Submission:** <https://www.saturday-am.com/>

TOKYOPOP

- **Why:** Veteran OEL publisher
- **Accepts:** Periodic submission windows for complete pitch packets
- **Your Advantage:** They’re actively expanding their “Global Manga” line
- **Submission:** <https://tokyopop.com/>

Antarctic Press

- **Why:** Long-standing independent, very accessible to newcomers
 - **Accepts:** Open submission policy for mini-series and ongoing titles
 - **Your Advantage:** Creator-friendly, fair contracts
 - **Submission:** <https://antarctic-press.com/>
-

Tier 3: Digital-First Platforms (Build Audience → Get Scouted)

WEBTOON Canvas

- **How:** Self-publish your manga; editors scout top performers for paid “Originals” contracts
- **Your Advantage:** No gatekeepers, immediate audience feedback

- **Monetization:** Ad revenue share + potential Originals deal
- **Submission:** <https://www.webtoons.com/en/>

Tapas

- **How:** Similar to WEBTOON; “Creator’s Program” for successful series
- **Your Advantage:** Smaller platform = easier to stand out
- **Submission:** <https://tapas.io/>

Manga Plus Creators (Shueisha)

- **How:** Upload directly; monthly awards judged by Shueisha editors
- **Your Advantage:** Direct pipeline to the world’s largest manga publisher
- **Submission:** <https://medibang.com/mpc/>

Tier 4: Contests (Direct Pipeline to Japanese Publishers)

Silent Manga Audition

- **Who:** Organized by COAMIX (Japanese publisher)
- **Your Advantage:** International contest, no dialogue required for entries
- **Prize:** Publication + serialization opportunity

Kodansha Creators Lab

- **Who:** Kodansha (Attack on Titan, Vinland Saga)
- **Your Advantage:** Contest-based entry to major publisher

Morning International Comic Competition

- **Who:** Kodansha’s “Morning” magazine
- **Your Advantage:** Specifically seeks international creators

How Much You Could Make

The Money Breakdown

Page Rates (During Serialization)

- **What:** Payment per page for magazine serialization
- **Range:** \$50–\$300/page (varies by publisher and your experience)
- **Example:** 20 pages/month at \$100/page = \$2,000/month while serialized

Advances (Upfront Payment)

- **What:** Lump sum paid when you sign the contract
- **Range:** \$1,000–\$25,000+ (depends on publisher size and your bargaining power)
- **How It Works:** Recouped from your future royalties; if you don’t earn it back, you keep it anyway
- **Example:** \$5,000 advance for a new creator at an independent publisher

Royalties (From Printed Volumes)

- **What:** Percentage of cover price per volume sold
- **Standard Rate:** 8%–15% of cover price
- **Example Calculation:**

- Volume 1 sells 10,000 copies at \$12.99 cover price
- 10% royalty = \$1.30 per book
- **Total: \$13,000**

Licensing & Secondary Rights

- **Anime Adaptation:** \$500–\$5,000+ per episode (negotiated separately)
 - **Merchandise:** 5%–10% of net sales
 - **International Licensing:** Varies widely
 - **Your Advantage:** You're writing in English, which is already a global language
-

Realistic Scenarios for “The Emperor Who Would Not Kneel”

Scenario 1: Small Press Deal

- **Publisher:** Antarctic Press or Saturday AM
- **Advance:** \$2,000–\$5,000
- **Page Rate:** \$75–\$150/page during serialization
- **Royalties:** 10% on print volumes
- **First Year Income:** \$5,000–\$15,000 (if serialized)

Scenario 2: Mid-Tier Publisher

- **Publisher:** Seven Seas, TOKYOPOP
- **Advance:** \$5,000–\$15,000
- **Page Rate:** \$100–\$200/page
- **Royalties:** 10%–12% on print volumes
- **First Year Income:** \$15,000–\$40,000 (if successful)

Scenario 3: Digital Platform → Originals Contract

- **Platform:** WEBTOON, Tapas
- **Initial:** Ad revenue (\$100–\$1,000/month while building audience)
- **Originals Contract:** \$800–\$3,000/month minimum guarantee
- **First Year Income:** \$10,000–\$36,000+

Scenario 4: Major Publisher (Dark Horse, Image)

- **Advance:** \$10,000–\$25,000+
 - **Page Rate:** \$150–\$300/page
 - **Royalties:** 12%–15%
 - **First Year Income:** \$25,000–\$75,000+ (if Arc 1 performs well)
-

Your Next Steps

Option A: Find an Artist First (Recommended)

1. Where to Find Artists:

- r/ComicBookCollabs (Reddit)
- DeviantArt job forums
- ArtStation
- Hire a manga artist (\$50–\$200/page for professional work)

2. What to Commission:

- 10–20 pages of fully finished art from Chapter 1 or 7
- Character turnaround sheets for main cast
- Cover art concept

3. Then Pitch to Publishers with a complete package**Option B: Self-Publish First, Get Scouted**

1. **Commission art for Chapter 1** (12 pages = ~\$600–\$2,400)
2. **Upload to WEBTOON Canvas or Tapas**
3. **Build an audience** (aim for 1,000+ subscribers)
4. **Get scouted** by editors for an Originals deal

Option C: Enter Contests

1. **Silent Manga Audition** (wordless manga contest)
2. **Kodansha Creators Lab**
3. **Winners get direct publication deals**

**Quick Action Plan for Next 30 Days****Week 1: Refine Your Pitch**

- [] Write a 1-sentence logline
- [] Write a 2-page synopsis (with ending)
- [] List 5 comparable titles
- [] Draft creator bio

Week 2: Visual Development

- [] Create character design briefs for Egris, Reaper, God, Satan
- [] Sketch rough turnarounds (or commission from artist)
- [] Select 10 pages from Chapter 1 to adapt as art sample

Week 3: Find Collaborators

- [] Post on r/ComicBookCollabs seeking manga artist
- [] Get quotes from 3–5 professional manga artists
- [] Join Discord communities (Manga Making, Comic Book Collabs)

Week 4: Start Submitting

- [] Research submission guidelines for top 5 publishers
- [] Submit to Saturday AM, Antarctic Press, Seven Seas
- [] Upload to WEBTOON Canvas or Tapas (if art is ready)

Your Competitive Advantages

1. **Complete Arc 1:** You have 12 polished chapters ready to go
 2. **Black Protagonist:** Diversity is in high demand; Saturday AM specifically seeks this
 3. **High Concept:** “Genghis Khan refuses God and Satan” is an instant hook
 4. **Timely Themes:** Philosophical action (à la Vinland Saga) is trending
 5. **English-First:** No translation needed for Western markets
 6. **Professional Format:** Your scripts are already in industry-standard manga format
-

Pro Tips

Do:

-  Follow submission guidelines exactly
-  Be professional and patient (response times: 3–6 months)
-  Submit to multiple publishers simultaneously (unless they require exclusivity)
-  Keep creating while you wait (start Arc 2!)

Don't:

-  Submit fan fiction or IP you don't own
 -  Ask for feedback if rejected (just thank them and move on)
 -  Submit script-only to publishers (they need art too)
 -  Give up after one rejection (persistence is key)
-

Resources

Communities

- r/manga
- r/ComicBookCollabs
- r/MangakaStudio
- Discord: “Manga Making” server

Learning

- YouTube: “Whyt Manga” (industry insights)
- YouTube: “EmmyMakes Manga” (creator journey)
- Book: The DC Comics Guide to Writing Comics by Dennis O’Neil

Contracts

- **Always get a lawyer** to review publishing contracts
 - **Understand:** Advance vs. royalty, IP ownership, reversion clauses
 - **Negotiate:** Royalty rates, foreign rights, digital rights
-

The Bottom Line

You have a publishable project. Arc 1 is complete, professional, and market-ready. Your biggest challenge is finding an artist to visualize your vision. Once you have 10–20 pages of finished art, you're ready to pitch.

Expected Timeline:

- Find artist: 1–2 months
- Commission sample pages: 1–3 months
- Submit to publishers: 1 day
- Wait for response: 3–6 months
- Negotiate deal (if accepted): 1–2 months
- **Total: 6–14 months from now to holding a contract**

Most Likely Path:

1. Commission 10–20 pages of art (\$600–\$4,000)
2. Submit to Saturday AM, Seven Seas, and Dark Horse
3. Simultaneously upload to WEBTOON Canvas
4. Land either a small press deal (\$2K–\$10K) OR build audience → Originals contract

Your manga is ready. Now go find your artist and make it real. 🔥